18. The letter was all the more awkward given Honecker had publicly listed at the 11th SED plenum in 1979 that anticipated deliveries of raw materials from the USSR over the period 1981–5 would include 19 million tons of crude oil, 6.5 billion cubic meters of natural gas and 4.2 million tons of hard coal per year. In fact, the only time Honecker's speech was interrupted by a wave of 'great applause' was when thanking Brezhnev for 'the understanding he showed for the specific problems of the GDR' – a reference to the promised quota of coal and oil imports, spun in the GDR press as a triumph of SED diplomacy. Compared to 1978, imports from the USSR constituted a 7 per cent increase in oil deliveries and a 7.7 jump in hard coal imports.

19. SAPMO-BA, DY 30 / J IV 2 / 2A / 2422.

20. Eventually lifted by President Reagan in June 1981.

21. Ibid. Letter from SED General Secretary Honecker to Brezhnev not to undermine the cornerstones of the existence of the GDR, 4 September 1981

22. On 15 September 1981.

23. Russian State Archive of Contemporary History. TsKhSD, f. 89, per. 42, no. 48, 'Ob itogakh poezdki t. Rusakova, K. V. v GDR, ChSSR, VNR, i NRB,' 29 October 1981, 2. Cited from The Rise and Fall of the Brezhnev Doctrine in Soviet Foreign Policy, Matthew J. Ouimet. University of North Carolina, 2003.

24. PREM19/471 f218 Record of a discussion between Prime Minister Margaret Thatcher and Chancellor Helmut Schmidt in Bonn, 17 November 1980

25. Pötzl . p.7

26. New York Times . 13 December 1981

27. In contrast, Hans-Dietrich Genscher privately told Margaret Thatcher, that he thought the GDR the 'most unstable state in Eastern Europe'. PREM19/471 f218 Record of a discussion between Prime Minister